Chapter Two

The Report Writing Process

Dr. Alshaimaa Adel Tantawy

Chapter Two Outlines

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Report Definition

- The word "**Report**" is derived from the Latin word of "**reportare**" which means **carry back**. ***Re*** means back and ***portare*** means to carry.
- **Report** is a description of an event carried back to someone who was not present on the scene.
- **Report** is a summary of findings and recommendations about a particular matter/problem.
- **Report** may be written for the guidance of higher authorities including company executives and directors.
- **Reports** facilitate timely decisions and follow up measures.

Report Definition

- **Report** a document containing information organized in a narrative, graphic, or tabular form, prepared on ad hoc, periodic, recurring, regular, or as required basis.
- **Reports** specific **periods**, **events**, **occurrences**, or **subjects**, and may be communicated or presented in oral or written form.

Report conveys information used to find facts or to assist in **decision making** or **solving business problems**. *Generally*, report is prepared and presented according to the **top management requirements**. Although **summaries** of reports may be delivered **orally**, **complete** reports are always in **written documents**.

Report Definition

Commonly, the report should give clear answers to the following questions:

- **What-** what was the topic/event/situation about?
- **Where-** where did it happen? Try to give an exact location.
- **When-** mention the specific date and time of the beginning of that event including its duration.
- **How-** Describe each detail of the event. It's a descriptive writing; you should include the minute details as well.
- **Why** -For what purpose did the event occur?

  The purpose should be specified.

Report Definition

From the previous definitions, it can be concluded that the meaning of the report; that

- **A report** is an **organized statement of facts/ information** relating to a particular subject prepared by reporter(s) after making independent inquiry or investigation with or without opinions or recommendations.

- A report should be in **clear** and **well-structured** format so that the information is easy to locate and follow.

The Report Importance

Reports may be written for many reasons, for example they may intend to:

- **inform;**
- **recommend;**
- **prompt or play a part in debate;**
- **reinforce or build on existing situations or beliefs;**
- **motivate;**
- **persuade;**
- **record;**
- **impress; or**
- **instruct.**

The Report Importance

The significance of the reports includes-

- Reports present **adequate information** on **various aspects** of the business.
- All the **skills** and the **knowledge** of the professionals are
- A rule and balanced report also helps in **problem solving**.
- Reports communicate the planning, policies and other matters regarding an organization to the masses.
- Reports help **Top Line** in **decision making**.
- **communicated** through reports.

The Report Writing Process

"To write is to think"

- Learning the **principles of reporting** takes time, and a report generally has to be **altered** many times, since its structure is subject to change while the writer's ideas become clearer over the course of time.
- It is worthwhile to get used to taking **systematic notes**, *for example* when reading books or having discussions with people.

The Report Writing Process

Now there is no single specific technique by which we can provide effective report writing process. Rather, there seem to be four main elements whose relationships with one another need to be balanced:

- **The writer**,
- **The content**; the object of the analysis or discussion,
- **The reader**; A writer write for a specific audience, *and*
- **The formal properties of the language itself**.

Not everybody will **balance** these elements in quite the **same way**; and this is as it should be, since there is no such thing as uniform, ideal academic English.

The Report Writing Process

Figure 2.1: The main elements of the report writing process.

Always write your report with this in mind that:

- you know the purpose of your report;
- you are able to provide all the facts and ideas about situations;
- someone else who may or may not know the whole situation is going to be reading it, commenting on it, discussing it and ultimately making a decision based upon it.

Stages of Report Writing Process

This is considered as a comprehensive guideline for writing any kind of report.

- Decide The Report Nature
- Decide the Report Purpose.
- Consider the Aim and Reader.
- Plan Investigative Approach.
- Collection of Information.
- Organize the collected Information.
- Analyzing and Interpreting the Information
- Decide the Report Contents
- Select the appropriate Title
- Brief Introduction

Stages of Report Writing Process

This is considered as a comprehensive guideline for writing any kind of report.

- Main body of the Report
- Decide on your recommendations.
- Summary of the Report
- End of the Report
- Format of a Report
- Plan the writing.
- Writing of First Draft
- Report Writing
- Edit and prepare the final copy.
- Report Presentation

Stages of Report Writing Process

In summary; these are some vital instruction for the report writing process:

- **Use separate pages for most sections;**
- **Use headings and a numbering system for sections;**
- **Give quotations from experts, facts and figures to support your opinions;**
- **Acknowledge your sources in text** (Name, year, page for quotations);
- **Be precise;**
- **Use formal impersonal language;**
- **Use clear language and short paragraphs;**
- **Label diagrams and tables**
- **Reference using the appropriate style.**

The Report Characteristics

To produce a perfect and comprehensive report; there are several basic characteristics should be accomplished when setting up or writing any type of reports:

- **Complete and Compact Document**
- **Provides Information and Guidance**
- **Systematic Presentation of Facts**
- **Prepared in Writing**
- **Acts as a Tool of Internal Communication**
- **Time Consuming and Costly Activity**
- **Acts as Permanent Record**
- **Self-explanatory Document**

Features of a Good Report

The report provides factual information depending on which decisions are made. So every care should be taken to ensure that a report has all the essential qualities. **A good report must have the following qualities:**

- ✓ **The Facts Correctness**
- ✓ **Reader- Orientation**
- ✓ **Unambiguous Language**
- ✓ **Conciseness**
- ✓ **Precision**
- ✓ **Clarity**
- ✓ **Accuracy**
- ✓ **Attractive Presentation**
- ✓ **Arrangement of Matters**
- ✓ **Grammatical Accuracy**
- ✓ **Unbiased Recommendation**
- ✓ **Simple Language**
- ✓ **Relevance**

Five Steps to Successful Writing

Successful writing is the result of knowing how to structure information using both **text** and **design** to achieve an intended **purpose** for a clearly defined **audience**. The best way to ensure that your writing will succeed—whether it is in the form of a specific type of report, memo, a résumé, a proposal, or a Web page—**is to approach writing using the following steps:**

1. **Preparation**
2. **Research**
3. **Organization**
4. **Writing**
5. **Revision**

Five Steps to Successful Writing

1. Preparation

Writing, like most professional tasks, requires solid preparation. In fact, adequate preparation is as important as writing a draft. In preparation for writing, **the goal is to accomplish the following four major tasks**:

- **Establish your primary purpose.**
- **Assess your audience (or readers) and the context.**
- **Determine the scope of your coverage.**
- **Select the appropriate medium.**

Five Steps to Successful Writing

2. Research

- **Research Methods.**

  (Primary research and Secondary research)

- **Information Sources.**

3. Organization

- **Development Methods.**
- **Outlining.**

Five Steps to Successful Writing

4. Writing

- When you have established your **purpose**, your readers' **needs**, and your **scope** and have completed your research and your **outline**.
- Write the **rough draft**, concentrating entirely on converting your outline into complete sentences and detailed paragraphs.
- Use your outline as a **map** for your first draft.
- Finally, write a **conclusion** that ties the main ideas together and emphatically makes a final significant point.

5. Revision

- **Read** your rough draft **several times**, each time looking for and correcting a different set of problems or errors.
- **Team members** must review each other's work on segments of the document as well as the final master draft.
- Use the **Checklist** of the Writing Process to guide you not only as you revise but also throughout the writing process.

Proof-reading Tips

Typically, if you commit errors in your technical communication, your readers will think one of two things about you and your company:

(1) They will conclude that you are unprofessional, or

(2) They will think that you are lazy.

In either situation, you ***lose***. Errors create a **negative impression** at best; at worst, a typographical error relaying false figures, calculations, amounts, equations, or scientific or medical data can be disastrous.

Proof-reading Tips

To ensure accurate report writing process, use the following Proofreading Tips.

- ☑ **Let someone else read it.**
- ☑ **Read backwards**
- ☑ **Use the gestation approach**
- ☑ **Read one line at a time or print it out**
- ☑ **Read long words syllable by syllable**
- ☑ **Utilize the appropriate technology**
- ☑ **Check figures, scientific and technical equations, and abbreviations.**
- ☑ **Read it out loud**
- ☑ **Use a dictionary.**
- ☑ **Try scattershot proofing**